

THE ECONOMY

With its rich farmland and mineral resources, Argentina is one of South America's most important economies. It is also self-sufficient in energy supplies and has large reserves of oil and gas. Despite its resources, Argentina has been badly run and has substantial overseas debts. A huge economic crisis in 2001 led to a collapse of confidence in the banking system. Many people withdrew their money from the banks.



Buenos Aires residents were among thousands of Argentinians who queued for hours to withdraw their savings during the crisis of 2001.



STEAM TRAINS

In 1857, a steam train made its way slowly south from Buenos Aires to the inland town of Las Flores, opening the first railroad line in Argentina. Within 40 years, the country was linked by more than 21,000 miles (34,000 km) of track. Largely built by British engineers with rolling stock constructed in British factories, this vast railroad system still runs cars and freight wagons, although diesel locomotives are now taking over.



The car industry is important to Argentina, and many of the leading manufacturers have factories there. Cars are made in the industrial centers of Buenos Aires, Córdoba, and Rosario.

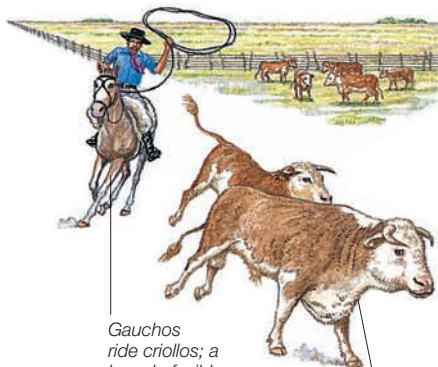
GOING TO SCHOOL

The literacy level of Argentina is one of the highest in South America. Primary education is compulsory up to the age of 12, although attendance is often low in country areas. In most state primary schools children wear white coats called *guarda polvo*, meaning "dust guard." The coats protect their clothes from chalk dust. About one-third of the students go on to attend one of the free state universities.



GAUCHOS OF THE PAMPAS

As famous as his northern cousin, the American cowboy, the Argentine gaucho has roamed the rolling plains of the pampas for about 300 years. The name gaucho comes from a South American word for outcast, since gauchos have always chosen to live beyond the law of the cities. The men work on the vast *estancias*, or ranches, fixing fences and corrals (pens for animals), tending the horses, and looking after the large herds of cattle. Tough, self-reliant, and free, the gauchos have become legendary heroes and a national symbol of Argentina.

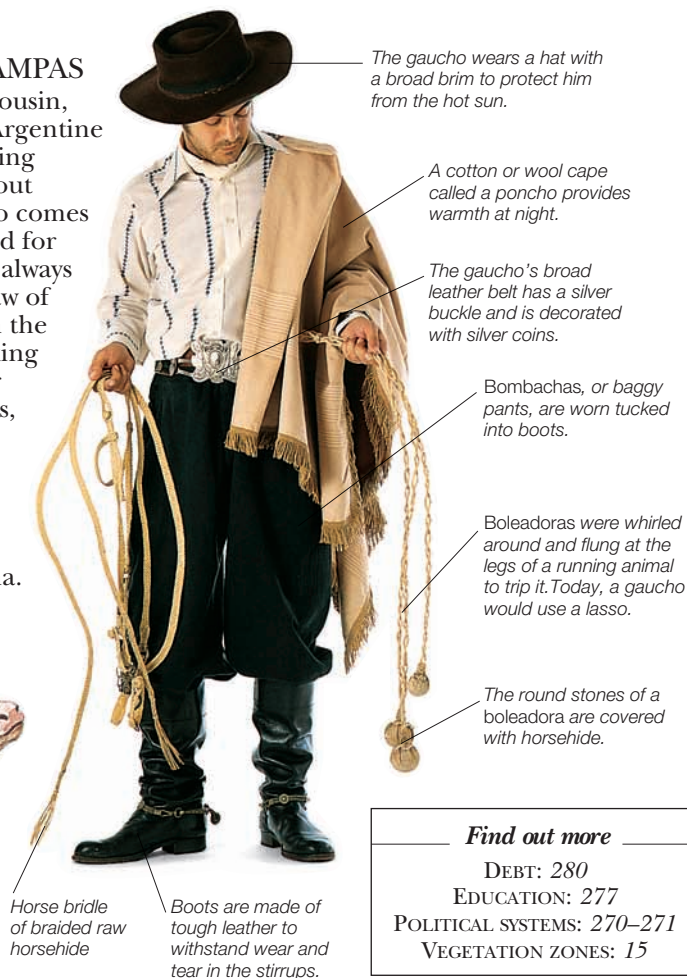


Gauchos ride criollos; a breed of wild horse that originally came from Mexico.

Beef cattle feed on pasture, or alfalfa mixed with grains of sorghum grass, to produce a leaner meat.

Gauchos regularly have to "throw a steer" to check for ticks and fleas.

To throw a steer, one man holds the animal by the horns, while another two men hold on to the tail.



The gaucho wears a hat with a broad brim to protect him from the hot sun.

A cotton or wool cape called a poncho provides warmth at night.

The gaucho's broad leather belt has a silver buckle and is decorated with silver coins.

Bombachas, or baggy pants, are worn tucked into boots.

Boleadoras were whirled around and flung at the legs of a running animal to trip it. Today, a gaucho would use a lasso.

The round stones of a boleadora are covered with horsehide.

Horse bridle of braided raw horsehide

Boots are made of tough leather to withstand wear and tear in the stirrups.

Find out more

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